

Confidential — Founder Strategy Brief

ShadowTalk AI

From zero revenue to first paying customers — a practical playbook for Zain Ahmed

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Repo: [zain836/shadowtalk-ai-903ca615](https://github.com/zain836/shadowtalk-ai-903ca615)

1. Executive Summary

ShadowTalk AI is a privacy-first AI chat platform built by a 17-year-old founder in Pakistan. The product has real traction — roughly **1,100 visitors** and **3,100 page views** over 90 days, with strong engagement (11+ minute average session) — but **\$0 revenue** because payments were never fully unblocked.

~48%
Traffic from United States

~20%
Traffic from Pakistan

63%
Bounce rate (room to improve)

36
Pricing page views (under-visited)

Core insight: You do not need Stripe from Pakistan to make money today. JazzCash, Easypaisa, bank transfer, and USDT are live paths. Card checkout via Lemon Squeezy is optional for US users.

2. Founder Context

Factor	Reality	Implication
Age & location	17, Pakistan	Stripe/card merchant accounts are difficult or unavailable
Audience split	US 48%, PK 20%	Need two payment rails: local wallets + international
Product maturity	Large codebase, many features shipped	Problem is conversion & deploy, not building more features
LinkedIn	480 connections, verified company	Trust channel for first PK customers + B2B leads
Revenue	\$0 to date	Every hour on new features < every hour on checkout + outreach

3. Product & Platform (What Exists)

Core product

- Private AI chat with stealth mode, offline/local AI options, multi-provider support
- Mission Control, agent tools, templates, themes, video studio (Pro+)
- Full admin panel, growth analytics, referral system
- PWA + desktop paths; professional UI on Lovable deployment

Growth engine — ShadowScale (built)

- Database migration + orchestrator/worker edge functions
- Admin Growth Command panel at `/admin`
- Referral notifications, share signals, video studio promo, cron automation

Content & viral assets (built)

- Remotion package: 60s 9:16 viral short compositions with TTS voiceover
- In-app Shadow Video Studio at `/video-studio` (Pro+ gated)

4. The Payment Problem (and the Fix)

Why revenue was \$0

1. Stripe does not work for a 17-year-old founder in Pakistan
2. Pricing page sent users to checkout, but receipt flow was WhatsApp-only
3. Admin “verify” updated payment status but did *not* activate user plans
4. Migrations and edge functions were not deployed to production Supabase
5. Frontend changes sat on branches without Lovable redeploy

Payment unblock — implemented (PR #105)

Channel	Details	Price (Pro example)
JazzCash	03211798561	Rs 1,499/mo
Easypaisa	03211798561	Rs 1,499/mo
Meezan Bank	IBAN PK08 MEZN 0099 1701 1274 9131	Rs 1,499/mo
USDT (TRC20)	TKfKJ7ESFcMTd2F1DkrvZ4buCWneAmHqz	~\$5/mo USD
Card (optional)	Lemon Squeezy when configured	\$5–20/mo

End-to-end flow (now)

1. User visits `/pricing` or `/founder-access?plan=pro`
2. Sees payment details (bank, wallet, crypto) + PKR prices
3. Signs in → uploads receipt in-app via Payment Receipt Form
4. Admin verifies at `/admin` → Manual Payments
5. `verify-manual-payment` edge function activates `subscribers` plan + sends notification

Deploy checklist (you must do on production):

1. Merge PR #105 and redeploy on Lovable
2. Run migration `20260611120000_payment_receipts_unblock.sql` in Supabase SQL editor
3. Deploy edge function: `supabase functions deploy verify-manual-payment`
4. Optional US cards: set Lemon Squeezy secrets + `VITE_LEMONSQUEEZY_VARIANT_*` env vars

5. Pricing Strategy

Plan	USD	PKR (wallets)	Target buyer
Pro	\$5/mo	Rs 1,499	Students, daily builders
Premium	\$15/mo	Rs 3,999	Power users, Mission Control
Elite	\$20/mo	Rs 5,999	Founders, agencies, teams

Default push: Premium (\$15) — best balance of value and revenue per customer. Pakistan: lead with Rs 3,999 and “unlimited + privacy.” US: lead with privacy angle + optional card checkout.

6. Go-to-Market Playbook

Week 1 — First 10 paying users

1. Deploy payment unblock (checklist above)
2. Post on LinkedIn (480 connections) — problem → product → JazzCash price → link
3. DM 20 people who engaged with your posts; offer Pro at Rs 1,499
4. WhatsApp status: screenshot of checkout + “DM for Pro”
5. Verify every receipt within 2 hours — speed builds trust

LinkedIn post template

Most AI tools remember everything you type. ShadowTalk doesn't.

I built ShadowTalk AI — private AI chat for students and builders in Pakistan (and globally).

Pro is Rs 1,499/month via JazzCash or Easypaisa. No Stripe needed.

Try it: shadowtalk-ai.com/founder-access?plan=pro

#AI #Pakistan #Startup #Privacy

US traffic (48%)

- USDT and Wise/SWIFT already on checkout page
- Configure Lemon Squeezy for instant card activation (no manual verify)

- Content angle: privacy, local-first AI, “not another ChatGPT wrapper”

Pakistan traffic (20%)

- JazzCash/Easypaisa is the conversion path — put number in every post
- WhatsApp follow-up after receipt submit
- University/college angle (Meritorious network) for student Pro tier

7. What NOT to Do Right Now

- **Don't build more features** before first payment — you have enough product
- **Don't chase Stripe** from Pakistan — use wallets + Lemon Squeezy for cards
- **Don't add heavy images/animations** to landing — hurts load time and SEO
- **Don't merge 50 PRs at once** — deploy payment PR, test, then iterate
- **Don't ignore /pricing** — only 36 views; every post should link to checkout

8. Technical Debt & Production Blockers

Blocker	Impact	Fix
Migrations not applied on live Supabase	Features break silently	Run SQL migrations in dashboard
Edge functions not deployed	Verify/receipt flow fails	Deploy via Supabase CLI or GitHub workflow
Lovable not redeployed	Users see old UI	Merge + trigger redeploy on gemini branch
SUPABASE_ACCESS_TOKEN missing	CI skips edge deploy	Add secret to GitHub Actions
Resend domain unverified	Feedback emails fail	Verify domain in Resend (lower priority)

9. Key URLs & Admin Paths

Purpose	URL
Checkout (Pro)	/founder-access?plan=pro
Checkout (Premium)	/founder-access?plan=premium

Pricing page	/pricing
Admin payments	/admin → Manual Payments
Growth Command	/admin → Growth Command
Video Studio	/video-studio (Pro+)

10. 30-Day Revenue Targets

Milestone	Target	How
Day 1–3	Deploy + 1 test payment	You pay Rs 1,499 yourself, verify in admin
Week 1	3 paying users	LinkedIn + WhatsApp + college network
Week 2	10 paying users	~Rs 15k–40k MRR depending on plan mix
Month 1	25 paying users	Referral loop + 1 viral short posted

North star: First Rs 1,499 hitting your JazzCash account from a stranger — not another feature shipped. Everything in this document exists to get you to that moment.

11. Conversation Log — Major Decisions

1. Accepted Pakistan-first payment rails (JazzCash, Easypaisa, bank, USDT) instead of waiting for Stripe
2. Built in-app receipt upload + admin verify → auto plan activation
3. Shipped ShadowScale growth engine for autonomous referrals and share signals
4. Built Remotion viral video pipeline + in-app Video Studio for content marketing
5. Identified deploy gap as root cause of “changes not showing” — merge + Lovable redeploy required
6. LinkedIn profile reviewed: verify badge, highlight ShadowTalk skills, point website to checkout
7. PR #105 opened: payment gateway unblock ready to merge

12. Next Actions (Priority Order)

1. ☐ Merge PR #105 → redeploy Lovable

2. ☐ Run payment migration on production Supabase
3. ☐ Deploy `verify-manual-payment` edge function
4. ☐ Test full flow: pay → submit receipt → admin verify → Pro active
5. ☐ Post LinkedIn announcement with checkout link
6. ☐ Set Lemon Squeezy variants for US card checkout (optional)
7. ☐ Record + post 1 viral short from Video Studio / Remotion

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This document reflects strategy discussions between founder and AI co-founder. Not financial or legal advice.